

A FREE GUIDE FROM BRAVEWORKS RN



ONE HUNDRED AND ONE

The BALANCED BP Reset

Your 101 Foods & Herbs Guide

A holistic food guide for your hormones, the
trigger behind your pressure.

Annie Chitate & Joel Polley

REGISTERED NURSES
JOEL: TWENTY YEARS, ICU AND EMERGENCY

BRAVEWORKS RN · [BPQUIZ.COM](https://bpquiz.com)

YOUR NEXT STEP, AND IT IS FREE

Beyond the Cuff. Live with Joel, every Monday.

7:00pm Central · on Zoom · free to attend

You are holding the guide. The guide tells you **what** to eat. The class tells you **why your body is doing this in the first place**, and that is the part almost nobody sits down and explains to you.

What we cover

- What is actually driving your reading, and why "it is just age and genetics" is the laziest answer in medicine.
- The three pressures behind almost every reading Joel saw in twenty years of ICU and emergency nursing, and the three hormones sitting underneath them.
- What changes for blood pressure after fifty, for women and for men, and why nobody warned you.
- How to work **with** your prescriber instead of around them, and the exact questions to ask at your next appointment.

Why come to the live one

- It is **live**, not a recording. Joel answers real questions from real people, out loud, for as long as it takes.
- It runs **this coming Monday** at 7:00pm Central, and every Monday after that.
- **A replay is not guaranteed.** Some weeks there is one, some weeks there is not. The live hour is the one we can promise.
- It is free, and there is nothing to buy on the call.

Come as you are. Most people on the call are over fifty. Roughly half are men. Almost all of them were handed a prescription and very little explanation. You will fit right in.

SAVE YOUR SPOT

bpquiz.com/masterclass

The page shows a countdown to the next live class. Bring a pen and your last few readings.

AND IF YOU WANT MORE AFTER THAT

Four steps, in order. None of them are required. The guide in your hands is complete on its own. Full details on the "Where to go next" page near the back.

\$17

The 10-Day BP Reset Kit

\$27/mo

The Weekly Reset community

\$297

Your personal 30-day protocol

\$1,997

The 90-Day programme

A holistic food guide for your hormones, the trigger behind your pressure.

This is not a diet. It is a repeatable system. Plant forward food, the eight BALANCED habits, and one small tweak a week. You are not being asked to be perfect. You are being asked to be consistent.

Why two nurses wrote one guide

Annie Chitate is a registered nurse who works with women through the hormone years. Joel Polley is a registered nurse who spent twenty years in ICU and emergency rooms watching blood pressure readings, and then went looking for what was pushing them.

For years we thought we were teaching two different subjects. We were not. **Blood pressure is a hormone story.** The three things that drive most readings are three hormones with three ordinary names, and once you see it that way, the food list in this guide stops being a random list of healthy things and starts being a plan.

What the research actually supports

- Plant based eating patterns are consistently linked with lower cardiovascular risk. More plants, better odds.
- The potassium to sodium ratio of your diet, not sodium alone, is what the kidney reads. Most people are only ever told half of that.
- Regular movement, around 150 minutes a week, protects the heart, the mood and sleep. Brisk walks count.
- Morning light sets the body clock that decides when your stress hormone rises and falls. Seven or more hours of sleep keeps that rhythm honest.
- Slow breathing and faith practice both show benefit for stress resilience.

None of that is exotic. All of it is free. That is the point of the whole guide.

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE, AND WE WILL SAY IT MORE THAN ONCE

Do not stop, skip, or change the dose of any medication because of this guide. Not one pill, not one day. Food and herbs work alongside your prescriber, never instead of your prescriber. If your numbers start moving, that is exactly the conversation to bring to your next appointment, with your written readings in hand. Your prescriber makes the medication decisions. Always.

Let food be thy medicine and medicine be thy food.

Attributed to Hippocrates

This guide is education and lifestyle support. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Nothing in these pages is a promise about your numbers. Run every change past the person who prescribes your medication, especially if you are pregnant, nursing, or living with kidney or heart disease.

Three rules, and then the list.

There are one hundred and one items in here. You are not supposed to buy all of them. Nobody does. Here is how the people who actually stick with this use it.

Rule one. Start with what is already in your kitchen.

Walk to your pantry with this guide open. You will find five or six items on the list that you already own and never thought of as blood pressure food. Onions. Oats. A can of black beans. A jar of cinnamon. Start there. Nothing kills a health change faster than a shopping trip you cannot afford.

Rule two. Add before you subtract.

Most people try to change their eating by taking things away, and most people quit in about nine days. We do it the other way. Crowd the plate with what belongs there and the rest gets pushed to the edges on its own. The one exception is the salt shaker, and even that one is a move, not a removal.

Rule three. One new food per day for ten days.

Not ten new foods today. One. Today spinach. Tomorrow garlic. The day after, oats. Ten days from now you will have ten new habits instead of one abandoned diet, and you will know which ones you actually like. There is a ten day starter near the back that does the choosing for you.

What every entry gives you

- **Why it helps.** The plain mechanism, named. Not "it is healthy." What the food actually does inside you, and which hormone it speaks to.
- **Good, better, best.** Three levels. Start where you are, upgrade when you are ready. No perfection drama.
- **Caution.** Only when there is a real one. If an item can interact with a medication you might be taking, it says so in plain words. Most items have no caution, and we did not invent any to look thorough.
- **A hormone tag.** Every single item is tagged with the hormone it works on, so you can read the list with a purpose instead of reading it like a phone book.

WHAT IS DELIBERATELY NOT IN HERE

Every drink in this guide is caffeine free. Stimulants push the stress hormone in exactly the wrong direction, so none of them appear on the list. **Every food in this guide is a plant.** There are no animal products anywhere, including in the serving suggestions. Where something needs sweetening, it is dates or maple. That is the NEWSTART standard the whole BraveWorks library is built on, and this guide holds to it without exception.

WHAT THIS GUIDE WILL NOT DO

It will not give you a number. You will not find "this drops your top number by X points" anywhere in these pages, because we cannot know that about you and neither can anyone selling you something. What food can do is give your body better raw material, and better raw material is what your prescriber is actually working with.

Three pressures. Three hormones. One story.

Blood pressure is a reading, not a disease. Something is pushing it. In Joel's twenty years of ICU and emergency nursing, the same three things did the pushing over and over again. We call them the three pressures. Stress, sugar, sodium. It is nothing mystical. It is a checklist.

Here is the part that almost nobody says out loud. **Each of those three pressures is a hormone.** Not a mood, not a habit, not a character flaw. A chemical messenger with a name, made in a gland, doing a job it was designed to do. That is why a hormone guide and a blood pressure guide turned out to be the same guide.

Stress is cortisol

Cortisol is made in your adrenal glands, the two small caps sitting on top of your kidneys. In a real emergency it is exactly what you want. It sharpens you up, raises the tone in your blood vessel walls so blood reaches the muscles, and tells your kidneys to hold on to sodium in case you are about to bleed.

The problem is that your body cannot tell the difference between a real emergency and a two in the morning worry about money. It answers both the same way. When cortisol stays high for months and years, the vessels stay a little tighter and the kidneys keep a little more sodium than they need to. Narrower pipes, plus more fluid, equals more pressure. **Nothing is broken. The alarm just never got switched off.**

Sugar is insulin

You eat fast carbohydrate, blood glucose rises, and insulin pours in to clear it. Insulin's day job is sugar. But insulin has two side effects that matter enormously here.

It signals the kidney to reabsorb more sodium instead of letting it go. And it turns up the sympathetic nervous system, the branch that tightens vessels and speeds the heart. So when insulin runs high for years, which is what insulin resistance means, you get sodium retention and vessel tightening from a hormone most people think has nothing to do with blood pressure at all. **This is why some people's readings are worst in the afternoon and they blame the salt on their sandwich.**

Sodium is aldosterone

Aldosterone is, quite literally, the body's salt and pressure hormone. It is made in the outer layer of the adrenal gland, and its whole job is to tell the kidney: keep sodium, let go of potassium. Water always follows sodium. More water in a closed system means more pressure inside it.

This is why the sodium corner is not really about the shaker. Your kidney is reading the **ratio** of potassium to sodium, hour by hour, and setting vessel tone from it. Most people are told to cut sodium and nobody ever tells them the other half, which is that raising potassium from food moves the same ratio. For most people, that half is far easier to actually do.

Cortisol feeds insulin. Insulin feeds aldosterone. The loop keeps turning until you interrupt it somewhere. Food is where most people can interrupt it.

WHY LICORICE IS BANNED FROM THIS GUIDE

This is the clearest proof that the three pressures are hormones. Licorice root contains a compound that blocks the enzyme protecting your kidney's aldosterone switch. Block that enzyme, and **your stress hormone starts acting like your salt hormone**. The result is sodium held, potassium dumped, and pressure pushed up. One herb, one enzyme, both hormones. That is why licorice is a hard no in this guide, and why you should read the label of every herbal blend you own.

Why your pressure changed when the rest of you did.

If your readings were fine for forty years and then quietly started climbing, you are not imagining it and you are not being careless. Three more hormone shifts arrive in mid life, and all three touch blood pressure.

For women: menopause

Oestrogen does a job most women are never told about. It helps the lining of your blood vessels produce **nitric oxide**, the signal that tells a vessel to relax and open. It is one of the quiet reasons women tend to have lower blood pressure than men through the middle decades of life.

When oestrogen falls at menopause, that help falls away. At the same time, arteries naturally stiffen with age. Put those together and blood pressure often begins to rise in the years around and after menopause. **Rising pressure after menopause is real, it is common, and it is badly under explained to women.** It is not a sign you did something wrong.

The food answer is not to replace the hormone. It is to feed the same pathway from the other end. Beets, leafy greens, arugula, watermelon, pomegranate and garlic all support the nitric oxide signal directly. That is why they are the first things on this list, and why they carry the gold tag.

For men: testosterone and the middle

Testosterone declines slowly from around the forties. As it does, body composition tends to shift, and fat gathers around the middle and around the organs rather than under the skin. That deep visceral fat is not passive storage. It is hormonally active tissue, and it drives insulin resistance.

So the male version of this story usually runs through the sugar corner. More visceral fat, more insulin resistance, more insulin, more sodium held by the kidney, more sympathetic tone. Same destination, different road. **The single most useful habit here is the walk after the meal.**

For everyone: the thyroid

Your thyroid sets the pace of the whole body, and it moves blood pressure in both directions depending on which way it drifts.

- **An underactive thyroid** tends to stiffen the blood vessels and slow the heart. The classic pattern is a bottom number that creeps up while the top number stays put.
- **An overactive thyroid** speeds the heart and widens the gap between the two numbers, so the top number climbs while the bottom number falls.

Both are common after fifty, both are easy to test for, and both are missed constantly. **If you have never had a thyroid panel, that is a reasonable thing to ask for at your next appointment.** The foods on this list that carry the thyroid tag give the gland the iodine and selenium it needs to do its job. They do not replace testing.

THE ENCOURAGING PART

Most hormone chaos is not permanent damage. It is interference. Stress, processed food, blood sugar swings, poor sleep and too little movement are the static between the signal and the cell. Take the interference away and give the body the raw material it needs, and it usually knows exactly what to do.

Your body is not broken. It is waiting for a different environment.

Start here. Eight things, and not one of them costs you a doctor visit.

You do not have to read the whole guide before you do something useful. Read this page, tick the boxes you can honestly do before you go to bed tonight, and start there.

- ☐ **Put one green on the plate at your biggest meal.**
Two handfuls of spinach wilted into whatever you are already cooking. It takes ninety seconds and it is the single highest value swap on this list.
- ☐ **Move the salt shaker off the table.**
Not out of your life. Off the table. Finish food with garlic, lemon, herbs or black pepper instead of the last shake.
- ☐ **Drink one tall glass of water right now.**
Then keep a glass in view for the rest of the day. Dehydration makes the body cling to sodium.
- ☐ **Rinse the can.**
Beans, corn or vegetables from a can, drained and rinsed under running water for thirty seconds. That one habit removes a meaningful share of the added sodium and costs you nothing.
- ☐ **Take a ten minute walk after dinner.**
Not a workout. A walk. Working muscle pulls sugar out of the blood without needing insulin to do it, and it settles the nervous system before bed.
- ☐ **Get outside within an hour of waking.**
Five to fifteen minutes of morning light sets the clock that decides when your stress hormone rises and falls. Sunglasses off if it is safe.
- ☐ **Set out one caffeine free infusion for tomorrow.**
Hibiscus if you have it. It is the drink in this guide with the most blood pressure research behind it.
- ☐ **Write down today's reading and today's date.**
One line in a notebook. You cannot see a trend you never wrote down, and a trend is what your prescriber will actually respond to.

THE RULE THAT OUTRANKS EVERYTHING ELSE ON THIS PAGE

Do not stop or change any medication because of this guide. Talk to your prescriber. Every single time. Bring your written readings with you.

If you want to know which of the three pressures is loudest in your own life, that is exactly what the free quiz at BPQuiz.com was built to answer. It takes about ninety seconds. You do not need it to use this guide. Start anywhere on the list and you are moving in the right direction.

BALANCED. Eight habits, eight hormone levers.

These are the eight NEWSTART laws of health in different words. Nutrition, exercise, water, sunlight, temperance, air, rest and trust in God. We spell them BALANCED because it is easier to remember at four in the afternoon when you are tired. Each letter pulls on a hormone, so each one is listed with the lever it moves.

Letter	Hormone lever	What you actually do
B Breathe & Belief	Cortisol	Three to five minutes of slow nasal breathing, plus two lines of gratitude or prayer. Slow breathing out is the fastest switch you own for stepping out of the alert state.
A Activity	Insulin	A twenty to thirty minute walk most days, plus two days a week of strength. Working muscle clears sugar from the blood without insulin, which lowers the whole insulin load of your day.
L Light	Cortisol rhythm	Five to fifteen minutes outside within an hour of waking. Dim the lights and put the screens down an hour before bed. Light is what tells cortisol when to rise and when to fall.
A Abundant Plants	Aldosterone	Half the plate vegetables, more green than any other colour, and one item from this list at every meal. This is where the potassium comes from, and potassium is the half of the ratio nobody tells you about.
N Nourish Water	Aldosterone	A tall glass on waking, a bottle with you all day, pale yellow as your check. When you run dry, the body holds sodium harder.
C Calm Moderation	Insulin	Limit added sugar, no stimulant drinks, screens down early. Temperance is simply learning the word "enough" for things that are not bad in themselves.
E Early Rest	Cortisol	Seven or more hours, same bedtime, dark and cool room. Short sleep raises the next day's cortisol and pushes the hunger hormones the wrong way, which lands you back in the sugar corner by three in the afternoon.
D Devotion & Depth	Cortisol	Five quiet minutes of prayer or scripture, one line of gratitude, one real conversation. People who nurture a faith practice show better stress resilience, and stress resilience is a blood pressure subject.

HOW TO USE THIS WITHOUT DROWNING

Pick **one letter** and own it this week. Not all eight. When it stops feeling like effort, add the next one. This is practical balance, not perfection, and when you hit a rough patch, and you will, BALANCED gives you a short list to come back to instead of a reason to quit.

Read this before you change anything.

Food is not neutral once you are on medication. Most of what follows is good news, but a few of these are real, and we would rather you be annoyed by this page than surprised by a lab result.

THE ONE THAT MATTERS MOST FOR THIS AUDIENCE

Potassium plus certain blood pressure medications. Half of this guide is potassium rich food, and potassium is exactly what most people need more of. But three families of medication make your body hold potassium instead of clearing it:

- **ACE inhibitors.** Names usually ending in "pril". Lisinopril, enalapril, ramipril, benazepril.
- **ARBs.** Names usually ending in "sartan". Losartan, valsartan, olmesartan, irbesartan.
- **Potassium sparing diuretics.** Spironolactone, eplerenone, triamterene, amiloride.

If you take one of these, or if you have any degree of kidney disease, **do not go from almost no potassium to a large amount overnight.** Build up gradually over weeks. Tell your prescriber you are adding potassium rich foods. Ask for a potassium level with your next routine bloodwork. That is a normal, easy request and any prescriber will understand it. Too much potassium in the blood is a genuine problem, and it is silent until it is not.

THE TRAP NOBODY WARNS PEOPLE ABOUT

Salt substitutes. The shaker labelled "no salt" or "lite salt" is usually potassium chloride. It is a concentrated potassium dose in a shaker, and it does not behave like the potassium in a banana. If you take an ACE inhibitor, an ARB, or a potassium sparing diuretic, ask your prescriber before you use one, every time. Getting potassium from food is safer than getting it from a shaker, and it works.

Licorice root raises blood pressure. It is a hard exclusion.

This one goes the wrong direction, so it is on the avoid list and it is not one of the 101. Glycyrrhizin, the compound in real licorice root, blocks the enzyme that protects your kidney's aldosterone switch. The result is your kidney holding sodium and dumping potassium at the same time, which is the exact opposite of everything else in this guide. It can raise blood pressure and lower potassium together.

Check every herbal blend in your cupboard. Licorice hides in a great many "throat", "digestive" and "detox" blends, in some sweets, and in real black licorice candy. Deglycyrrhizinated licorice, labelled DGL, has had the offending compound removed and is a different thing.

Hawthorn adds to your medication

Hawthorn is the traditional Western heart herb and people ask about it constantly, so here is the straight answer. **Hawthorn can potentiate blood pressure medication**, meaning it adds to the effect of the pill you are already taking and can take your pressure lower than anyone planned. It also **interacts with digoxin**. Low blood pressure lands people in the emergency department too.

Do not start hawthorn on your own if you take a blood pressure medication or digoxin. Ask your prescriber first, every time. It appears in this guide, at number 97, with that same warning attached to it.

SAY THIS AT YOUR NEXT APPOINTMENT

"I am adding more potassium rich plant foods and a few kitchen herbs to my routine. I am not changing any of my medications. Can we check a potassium level next time, and is there anything on this list you want me to avoid?" Take the guide with you. It was written to be readable in an exam room.

Five more, then we get to the food.

Grapefruit, and why it is not one of the 101

Grapefruit blocks an enzyme in your gut that breaks down certain drugs, which can push blood levels of those drugs higher than intended. It matters most with **several statins** and with **some calcium channel blockers**, including certain forms of nifedipine and felodipine. Grapefruit is a healthy fruit. It is deliberately left off this list anyway, because we cannot know what is in your pill box. If you love it, ask your prescriber or your pharmacist first. A pharmacist will answer this in one minute and will be glad you asked.

Garlic, ginger and concentrated omega 3, if you take a blood thinner

Garlic, ginger, turmeric, cayenne and high dose plant omega 3 supplements all have a mild antiplatelet effect. In the amounts you use to cook, that is not a concern for most people. If you take **warfarin, clopidogrel, apixaban, rivaroxaban or daily aspirin**, keep herbs to normal culinary amounts, skip the concentrated capsules unless your prescriber has approved them, and **tell your surgeon or your dentist about every herb and supplement you take before any procedure**.

Warfarin and leafy greens: consistency, not avoidance

If you take warfarin, the goal is **consistency**. Greens are high in vitamin K, and warfarin is dosed against your usual vitamin K intake. Swinging from no greens to a mountain of greens is what causes trouble. Pick an amount you can repeat most days, tell your prescriber you are doing it, and let them adjust to you. Do not quietly cut greens out either. Steady is the whole word.

Everyday pain relievers work against you

Ibuprofen, naproxen and the rest of the NSAID family make your kidneys hold sodium and fluid, and they blunt several blood pressure medications. Occasional use for a headache is one conversation. Daily use for arthritis is another, and it is worth raising with your prescriber, because it may be quietly costing you every single day.

Cold and sinus medicines

Pseudoephedrine and phenylephrine constrict blood vessels by design. That is how they clear a blocked nose. Read the label on anything you buy for a cold, and ask a pharmacist for a version that is appropriate with your blood pressure.

SIGNS TO STOP AND CALL SOMEONE

Dizziness on standing, new lightheadedness, fainting, a reading much lower than your normal, new muscle weakness, a slow or irregular heartbeat, or new swelling. Any of those, stop the new herb and call your prescriber.

Chest pain, trouble breathing, weakness on one side of the body, or a sudden severe headache is not a phone call. That is 911.

Nothing in this guide is a substitute for the judgement of the person who prescribes your medication. The interactions listed here are the common, well documented ones, and no list can be complete for every person or every prescription. Your pharmacist has your full medication list in front of them and will check any of this for free.

What to leave out.

This guide is built almost entirely on what to add. There is only a handful of things worth deliberately leaving out, and none of them will surprise you except maybe the last two.

Leave out or limit	What it does
Licorice root	Raises blood pressure and lowers potassium through the aldosterone pathway. The one herb on this page that is a hard no, in any blend, at any dose.
Caffeine, in every form	Coffee, black tea, green tea, matcha, energy drinks and cola all trigger an adrenaline release, raise heart rate and tighten vessels. They pour fuel on a stress corner that is usually already running hot. Every drink in this guide is caffeine free on purpose.
Animal products	The whole of this guide is plant based, in line with the NEWSTART pattern. Where a recipe wants sweetness, use dates or maple.
Salt substitutes, unless cleared	Concentrated potassium chloride in a shaker. Ask your prescriber first if you take an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or a potassium sparing diuretic.
Daily NSAIDs	Sodium and fluid retention, plus a blunting effect on several blood pressure medications.
Alcohol	Raises pressure and wrecks the deep sleep your body uses to reset cortisol overnight.
The salt shaker at the table	Not salt itself. The reflex. The shake you do before you have tasted the food is pure habit, and habit is the easiest thing on this page to change.
Salted roasted nuts and seeds	Everything in the nut section is here for its magnesium and potassium. The salted version hands most of that straight back. Buy raw or dry roasted, unsalted.

How to read the list

Every one of the 101 items carries a tag, and the tag is the hormone it mainly speaks to. Some items carry two, because some foods genuinely do two jobs. Read the tags and you will see the whole mechanism of this guide printed on every single line.

THE FIVE TAGS

- CORTISOL** Magnesium, calm, sleep, the stress axis. Helps the alarm switch off.
- INSULIN** Fibre, slow carbohydrate, a steadier blood sugar curve. Less insulin, less sodium held.
- ALDOSTERONE** Potassium and fluid balance. Moves the potassium to sodium ratio your kidney reads.
- NITRIC OXIDE** Nitrate and polyphenols. Feeds the vessel relaxing signal that oestrogen used to help produce.
- THYROID** Iodine and selenium. Raw material for the gland that sets the pace of everything.

Sections one to nine are food. You do not need permission to eat food. **Section ten is different.** Those five are herbs used at strength. The risk is not poison, the risk is **addition**. A herb that relaxes vessels, on top of a pill that relaxes vessels, on top of a water pill, can take your pressure lower than anyone planned. Take that page to your prescriber before you start any of them.

The Foundation Ten

ITEMS 1 TO 10 · IF YOU ONLY EVER ACT ON ONE PAGE, MAKE IT THIS ONE

Food is medicine, but most people need a road map. These ten are the ones we would put in the cart first: common, cheap, shelf stable enough that you will actually use them, and each one working on a named hormone. Under thirty dollars in most stores. If money is tight this month, buy in this order: beans, oats, onions, flaxseed, cabbage.

1 Ground Flaxseed INSULIN NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Lignans and plant omega 3 fats, plus soluble fibre that slows how fast sugar reaches the blood. Less sugar rush means less insulin, and less insulin means less pressure on the kidney to hold sodium.

GOOD A teaspoon on oats. / **BETTER** A tablespoon in a smoothie. / **BEST** Two tablespoons a day, ground fresh and kept in the fridge.

CAUTION It must be ground, not whole. Whole seed passes straight through you.

2 Spinach ALDOSTERONE NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Potassium, magnesium and natural nitrate in one leaf. Your kidney reads the potassium to sodium ratio hour by hour, and this is the cheapest way to move the half nobody talks about.

GOOD Fresh in a sandwich. / **BETTER** Two handfuls wilted into soup, beans or a pasta sauce. / **BEST** Two cups raw in a daily green smoothie.

CAUTION High in vitamin K. On warfarin, keep the amount steady rather than cutting it out.

3 Beets NITRIC OXIDE ALDOSTERONE

WHY The richest common food source of dietary nitrate. Your body turns nitrate into nitric oxide, the same relaxing signal that oestrogen used to help produce, which tells the vessel lining to open rather than grip.

GOOD Roasted as a side. / **BETTER** Half a cup of cooked or jarred beets, three or four times a week. / **BEST** Raw beet blended into a juice or smoothie with apple and ginger.

CAUTION Pink urine afterwards is harmless and normal. Do not be alarmed by it.

4 Garlic NITRIC OXIDE CORTISOL

WHY Crushing garlic makes allicin, one of the most studied plant compounds in vascular research. It supports the relaxing signal in the vessel wall, and it makes food taste finished without salt.

GOOD Raw in a dressing. / **BETTER** Two cloves crushed into cooking daily. / **BEST** Crush it, let it sit ten minutes, then cook. The rest is when the allicin forms.

CAUTION Mild blood thinning effect. Keep to cooking amounts on warfarin, clopidogrel, apixaban, rivaroxaban or daily aspirin, and tell your surgeon or dentist before any procedure.

5 Rolled Oats INSULIN

WHY Beta glucan, a soluble fibre that turns to gel and slows sugar into the blood. A steadier sugar curve means a steadier insulin curve, and insulin is the hormone hiding behind the sugar corner.

GOOD Overnight oats. / **BETTER** Half a cup dry, cooked in water, with berries. / **BEST** Steel cut, with ground flaxseed and cinnamon stirred through.

6 Black Beans ALDOSTERONE INSULIN

WHY Potassium, magnesium, soluble fibre and plant protein in the same spoonful. It works the salt corner and the sugar corner at the same time, which almost nothing else on this list does.

GOOD In tacos. / **BETTER** Half a cup a day into anything savoury. / **BEST** Cooked from dry with cumin and lime, so you control every grain of salt.

CAUTION Rinse canned beans under running water for thirty seconds. It washes away a meaningful share of the added sodium.

7 Hibiscus ALDOSTERONE CORTISOL

WHY A deep red, tart, caffeine free flower infusion, and the drink with the most blood pressure research behind it. It is also the easiest swap in this guide for the afternoon soda habit.

GOOD One cup in the evening. / **BETTER** One cup morning and evening. / **BEST** Steeped strong, cooled, and drunk through the day from a jug.

CAUTION Read the blend. A great many "herbal" mixes hide licorice root, which pushes the wrong way. Hibiscus should be the first ingredient.

8 Avocado ALDOSTERONE CORTISOL

WHY More potassium than a banana, plus magnesium and monounsaturated fat. Magnesium is the mineral the muscle in your vessel walls needs in order to let go rather than grip.

GOOD Slices on toast. / **BETTER** Half an avocado most days. / **BEST** Blended into a dressing or a smoothie for creaminess without dairy.

9 Sweet Potato INSULIN ALDOSTERONE

WHY A slow carbohydrate carrying potassium, fibre and beta carotene. It gives you the comfort of a starch without the sharp spike that drags insulin up behind it.

GOOD Baked wedges. / **BETTER** Mashed with olive oil and herbs. / **BEST** Cooked, cooled overnight, then reheated. Cooling raises the resistant starch.

10 Berries INSULIN NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Blueberries, raspberries and strawberries carry polyphenols that support the lining of your blood vessels, and they do it with very little sugar load.

GOOD A handful on breakfast. / **BETTER** Mixed into oats or chia pudding. / **BEST** A cup of frozen mixed berries daily. Frozen is cheaper and often picked riper.

Greens and Vegetables

ITEMS 11 TO 29 · WHERE THE POTASSIUM LIVES

Aim for more green on the plate than any other colour. Dark leaves carry potassium, magnesium and natural nitrate, and the cruciferous family supports the liver pathways that break down used hormones so they leave the body instead of circulating around it again.

11 Kale ALDOSTERONE NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Potassium, calcium and vitamin K, plus fibre that helps carry used hormones out through the gut rather than letting them recirculate.

GOOD Chopped into a salad. / **BETTER** Sauteed with garlic and lemon. / **BEST** Massaged with olive oil to soften, or blended into a smoothie.

CAUTION High vitamin K. On warfarin, keep the amount steady week to week.

12 Swiss Chard CORTISOL ALDOSTERONE

WHY One of the highest magnesium greens on this list, and magnesium runs low in people living under long stress.

GOOD Stems and leaves chopped into soup. / **BETTER** Sauteed with onion and garlic. / **BEST** The big leaves used as a wrap instead of bread.

CAUTION High vitamin K, same warfarin rule as above.

13 Arugula NITRIC OXIDE

WHY One of the highest nitrate greens there is, which feeds the nitric oxide signal that tells vessels to widen. Peppery enough that it seasons a plate on its own.

GOOD A handful on top of anything. / **BETTER** A whole plate of it as the salad base. / **BEST** Blended into a green sauce with lemon, walnuts and olive oil.

14 Romaine and Dark Leaf Lettuce ALDOSTERONE

WHY Water, potassium and minerals with almost no sodium at all. The cheapest possible way to shift the ratio your kidney is reading.

GOOD A side salad with the meal. / **BETTER** Big leaves used instead of bread. / **BEST** Rotate varieties. The darker the leaf, the more it carries.

15 Watercress NITRIC OXIDE THYROID

WHY One of the most nutrient dense greens on earth for its weight, and it supports the liver in clearing used oestrogen properly.

GOOD A handful in a salad. / **BETTER** Blended into a soup at the end of cooking. / **BEST** Made the base green of your lunch bowl.

16 Broccoli INSULIN

WHY Sulforaphane and fibre. It supports the liver pathways that break down used hormones, which is the difference between clearing oestrogen and recycling it.

GOOD Steamed florets. / **BETTER** Roasted with olive oil and lemon. / **BEST** Lightly cooked so it still has a crunch. Overcooking costs you most of the benefit.

17 Cauliflower INSULIN

WHY A cruciferous vegetable that stands in for white starch. Fewer fast carbohydrates on the plate means a calmer insulin response after the meal.

GOOD Steamed florets. / **BETTER** Mashed instead of potato. / **BEST** Riced as the base under beans and greens.

18 Brussels Sprouts INSULIN

WHY Fibre and sulphur compounds that support hormone clearance through the liver and the gut together.

GOOD Steamed lightly. / **BETTER** Roasted until the edges brown and crisp. / **BEST** Shaved raw into a slaw with lemon.

19 Cabbage INSULIN ALDOSTERONE

WHY Cheap, keeps for weeks in the fridge, and rich in the compounds that help the liver process oestrogen. Pound for pound the best value vegetable on this list.

GOOD Shredded into a slaw. / **BETTER** Braised slowly with onion. / **BEST** Fermented into sauerkraut, which adds the gut benefit on top.

20 Celery ALDOSTERONE

WHY Water, potassium and natural compounds traditionally used to support relaxed vessel walls. The leaves carry more than the stalks do.

GOOD Snack sticks with hummus. / **BETTER** The base of every soup and stew you make. / **BEST** Juiced with cucumber and lemon in the morning.

CAUTION Celery carries more natural sodium than most vegetables. That is fine from the plant. It is not the same thing as the shaker.

21 Carrots INSULIN

WHY Fibre and carotenoids, and a naturally sweet snack that does not spike the way sweets do.

GOOD Raw sticks. / **BETTER** Lightly steamed, which improves how much of the carotenoid you absorb. / **BEST** Shredded raw into salads and wraps for bulk.

22 Tomatoes NITRIC OXIDE ALDOSTERONE

WHY Potassium and lycopene, which supports the vessel lining. Cooking them with a little fat frees more of the lycopene than eating them raw.

GOOD Fresh slices. / **BETTER** Cooked with olive oil. / **BEST** A homemade sauce, so you control the salt.

CAUTION Jarred sauces and canned tomato products are often extremely high in sodium. Read the label and compare brands.

23 Onions NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Quercetin and sulphur compounds that support the vessel wall. Just as usefully, they make food taste like something without any salt at all.

GOOD Raw in a salad. / **BETTER** Sauteed as the base of nearly everything. / **BEST** Roasted whole until sweet, or red onion raw for the higher antioxidant content.

24 Asparagus ALDOSTERONE

WHY A gentle natural diuretic carrying folate and potassium. It helps the body release extra fluid without needing a pill to do it.

GOOD Steamed. / **BETTER** Roasted with lemon and black pepper. / **BEST** Shaved raw into a salad with olive oil.

25 Zucchini ALDOSTERONE INSULIN

WHY Water and potassium, and it gives you volume on the plate without the starch load that pulls insulin up.

GOOD Sauteed with garlic. / **BETTER** Roasted with herbs. / **BEST** Spiralised as noodles under a tomato sauce.

26 Eggplant INSULIN

WHY Soluble fibre plus the dark skin pigments that support the heart and the vessel lining. Meaty enough to carry a whole meal.

GOOD Roasted slices. / **BETTER** Blended into a dip with tahini, garlic and lemon. / **BEST** Grilled with olive oil and fresh herbs.

CAUTION The old trick of salting it before cooking adds sodium. Modern varieties are rarely bitter, so skip it, or rinse well afterwards.

27 Bell Peppers NITRIC OXIDE

WHY More vitamin C by weight than an orange, and vitamin C supports the enzyme that produces the vessel relaxing signal.

GOOD Raw strips with hummus. / **BETTER** Roasted and blended into a sauce. / **BEST** Eat a mix of colours through the week, each one carries something different.

28 Mushrooms CORTISOL ALDOSTERONE

WHY A deep savoury flavour that lets you cut salt without missing it, plus potassium and the B vitamins the adrenal glands run on.

GOOD Sauteed with garlic. / **BETTER** Roasted until well browned, as a burger swap. / **BEST** Dried mushrooms rehydrated, then the soaking water used as a salt free flavour base.

29 Butternut Squash INSULIN ALDOSTERONE

WHY Potassium and a slow carbohydrate that is sweet enough to satisfy a craving without the crash that follows sugar.

GOOD Roasted cubes. / **BETTER** Blended into a soup with ginger. / **BEST** As the base of a bowl in place of white rice.

Fruits and Sweet Plants

ITEMS 30 TO 42 · POTASSIUM IN ITS EASIEST FORM

Fruit is where most people find potassium without thinking about it. Eat it whole rather than juiced, because the fibre is what keeps the sugar slow. A note that runs through this whole section: dried fruit is concentrated, which makes it both the most efficient potassium on the list and the one to build up to gradually if you are on an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or spironolactone.

30 Bananas ALDOSTERONE

WHY The potassium everybody has already heard about. It is real, it is cheap, and it is the easiest first step there is.

GOOD One a day. / **BETTER** Slightly green, which carries more resistant starch and less sugar. / **BEST** Frozen and blended into a smoothie with greens and flaxseed.

CAUTION On an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or spironolactone, do not jump from none to several a day. Build up over weeks and ask for a potassium check.

31 Oranges and Citrus NITRIC OXIDE CORTISOL

WHY Vitamin C, potassium and flavonoids. Your adrenal glands hold one of the highest concentrations of vitamin C anywhere in the body, and they use it hardest under stress.

GOOD Whole fruit rather than juice. / **BETTER** Keep the white pith on, that is where the fibre is. / **BEST** Zest grated into dressings for flavour instead of salt.

CAUTION Grapefruit is deliberately not on this list. See the interactions pages before you eat it with a statin or a calcium channel blocker.

32 Apples INSULIN

WHY Pectin, a soluble fibre that slows sugar and feeds the gut bacteria involved in clearing used hormones.

GOOD Fresh with the skin on. / **BETTER** Baked with cinnamon instead of dessert. / **BEST** Sliced with nut butter, so the fat slows the sugar further still.

33 Pears INSULIN

WHY Gentle fibre for digestion and a genuinely slow sugar release. One of the kindest fruits on a sensitive stomach.

GOOD Fresh, ripe. / **BETTER** Poached with cinnamon and cloves. / **BEST** Diced into oats at breakfast.

34 Kiwi NITRIC OXIDE ALDOSTERONE

WHY Vitamin C, potassium and fibre in a very small package, which makes it easy to eat two.

GOOD Cut in half, eat with a spoon. / **BETTER** Eat the skin, it is edible and holds most of the fibre. / **BEST** Two a day as your standing fruit habit.

35 Pomegranate NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Polyphenols studied for their support of the vessel lining and healthy blood flow. One of the strongest nitric oxide foods on the list.

GOOD Seeds sprinkled over a salad. / **BETTER** A small glass of unsweetened juice. / **BEST** The whole seeds, fibre and all.

CAUTION There is some evidence pomegranate juice may affect the same drug enzyme grapefruit does. If you take a statin or a calcium channel blocker, ask your pharmacist first.

36 Watermelon NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Water, potassium and citrulline, which the body uses in the very pathway that produces the vessel relaxing signal.

GOOD Fresh slices. / **BETTER** Blended with lime as a drink instead of soda. / **BEST** Include a little of the pale rind, which carries the most citrulline of all.

37 Grapes NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Resveratrol and other polyphenols, almost all of them concentrated in the dark skins.

GOOD A small bunch. / **BETTER** Frozen, as a dessert that takes ten seconds to prepare. / **BEST** Dark or red varieties rather than pale green.

38 Prunes **ALDOSTERONE** **INSULIN**

WHY One of the highest potassium foods by weight, with the fibre to keep everything moving. Very useful if fresh fruit is hard for you to get or to chew.

GOOD Three or four as a snack. / **BETTER** Chopped into oats. / **BEST** Blended into a paste and used to replace sugar in baking.

CAUTION Concentrated potassium. Build up slowly on an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or spironolactone.

39 Dried Apricots **ALDOSTERONE**

WHY Very high potassium in a small handful, and shelf stable, so there is no excuse about the shopping.

GOOD Five or six as a snack. / **BETTER** Chopped into a grain bowl. / **BEST** Unsulphured varieties. They are darker and less processed.

CAUTION Concentrated potassium, same rule as prunes. Build up slowly and tell your prescriber.

40 Dates **INSULIN**

WHY This is the sweetener the whole guide uses in place of honey, and it arrives with fibre, potassium and magnesium attached rather than stripped away.

GOOD One or two as a treat. / **BETTER** Blended into a smoothie for sweetness. / **BEST** Soaked and mashed into a paste to replace sugar in baking.

CAUTION Still concentrated sugar. Two or three, not a handful.

41 Figs **ALDOSTERONE**

WHY Calcium, potassium and fibre together. Dried figs are one of the better plant calcium sources, which matters for bones after menopause.

GOOD Fresh, in season. / **BETTER** Two dried figs with a few walnuts for steady energy. / **BEST** Blended into energy balls with dates and oats.

42 Mango **INSULIN** **NITRIC OXIDE**

WHY Vitamin A, vitamin C and enzymes that help digestion, in a fruit sweet enough to end a meal on.

GOOD Fresh chunks. / **BETTER** Frozen into smoothies. / **BEST** With lime and a pinch of chilli, instead of dessert.

Beans, Lentils and Soy

ITEMS 43 TO 52 · THE CHEAPEST HORMONE FOOD THERE IS

Protein and fibre arriving together is the calmest possible signal you can send to insulin. Beans also carry potassium and magnesium, which puts them in two corners at once. One rule applies to every canned item in this section: drain it and rinse it under running water for thirty seconds. That habit alone removes a meaningful share of the added sodium, and it costs nothing.

43 Lentils, Green and Brown INSULIN ALDOSTERONE

WHY Cheap plant protein with fibre, folate and potassium. No soaking needed, and they hold their shape.

GOOD In a soup. / **BETTER** As a patty, or as a savoury sauce over pasta. / **BEST** Sprouted, which makes them easier to digest and richer in enzymes. Sprout your own from dry in two or three days.

44 Red Split Lentils INSULIN

WHY They cook in fifteen minutes with no soaking at all, which removes the main excuse people give for not eating beans.

GOOD Simmered into a soup. / **BETTER** Spiced into a dal with turmeric and cumin. / **BEST** Stirred into any sauce to add protein quietly.

45 Chickpeas INSULIN ALDOSTERONE

WHY Fibre, protein and potassium, and the most versatile bean in the cupboard by a distance.

GOOD Roasted crunchy, instead of chips. / **BETTER** Hummus with raw vegetables. / **BEST** Into curries and hearty stews.

CAUTION Rinse the can.

46 Kidney Beans INSULIN

WHY Iron, fibre and a slow carbohydrate that keeps you full for hours.

GOOD In chilli. / **BETTER** In a mixed bean salad with lemon and parsley. / **BEST** With brown rice, which completes the protein.

CAUTION If cooking from dry, boil hard for at least ten minutes. Undercooked kidney beans can genuinely make you unwell.

47 White Beans, Cannellini and Navy ALDOSTERONE

WHY Among the highest potassium beans there are, and creamy enough to blend into sauces without any dairy.

GOOD In a soup. / **BETTER** Blended into a creamy dip with garlic and lemon. / **BEST** Half a cup daily as your standing potassium habit.

CAUTION High potassium. Build up gradually on an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or spironolactone.

48 Pinto Beans INSULIN

WHY Soluble fibre that steadies blood sugar and feeds the gut bacteria doing the quiet work of hormone clearance.

GOOD Mashed with olive oil and cumin, never with animal fat. / **BETTER** In a burrito bowl with greens and salsa. / **BEST** Cooked from dry in a slow cooker with onion and garlic.

49 Split Peas INSULIN

WHY Fibre and protein that hold you for hours, which quietly ends the afternoon snacking that keeps insulin running high all day.

GOOD Classic split pea soup. / **BETTER** A curried stew with carrot and celery. / **BEST** Blended thick and used as a sauce over grains.

50 Edamame INSULIN

WHY Whole young soybeans, carrying protein, fibre and isoflavones, the gentle plant compounds most studied in the menopause years.

GOOD Steamed from frozen as a snack. / **BETTER** Tossed through a stir fry. / **BEST** Blended into a bright green dip with lemon and mint.

CAUTION Buy them plain. The pre salted packets can carry a great deal of sodium.

51 Tofu **INSULIN**

WHY Plant protein with almost no effect on blood sugar, which makes it a calm centre for a plate that would otherwise be all carbohydrate.

GOOD Pan seared with coconut aminos. / **BETTER** Steamed five minutes, marinated, then baked until the edges caramelise. / **BEST** Crumbled into a savoury scramble with turmeric and greens.

CAUTION If you take thyroid medication, soy can interfere with how much you absorb. Keep soy intake consistent and leave about four hours between your thyroid tablet and soy foods. Ask your prescriber.

52 Tempeh **INSULIN**

WHY Fermented soy, so you get the protein and the live culture benefit in the same block. Firmer and nuttier than tofu.

GOOD Sliced and pan fried. / **BETTER** Marinated in tamari, garlic and ginger, then baked. / **BEST** Crumbled as the savoury base of a chilli.

CAUTION Tamari and soy sauce are salt. Use a teaspoon, not a splash, and count it as the salt for that meal.

Grains and Smart Carbs

ITEMS 53 TO 60 · THE SUGAR CORNER, HANDLED

You do not have to give up carbohydrate. You have to slow it down. Whole grains arrive with their fibre and minerals still attached, which is the entire difference between a gentle rise in blood sugar and a spike that drags insulin up behind it. Two tricks run through this section: cook a batch and cool it, because cooling raises resistant starch, and always eat the grain alongside a bean or a fat.

53 Quinoa INSULIN CORTISOL

WHY A complete plant protein carrying magnesium, the mineral a jumpy stress response burns through fastest.

GOOD As a simple side. / **BETTER** The base of a bowl with beans and greens. / **BEST** As a breakfast porridge with berries and seeds.

CAUTION Rinse it well before cooking to wash off the naturally bitter coating.

54 Barley INSULIN

WHY Even more beta glucan than oats. That is the same gel forming fibre that slows sugar and steadies the whole insulin response of a meal.

GOOD Stirred into a soup. / **BETTER** As a chewy salad base instead of rice. / **BEST** Cooked in a batch on Sunday for the week.

CAUTION Contains gluten. Not for coeliac disease.

55 Brown Rice INSULIN

WHY The fibre, magnesium and B vitamins that white rice has had milled out of it.

GOOD Steamed with vegetables. / **BETTER** As a stir fry base. / **BEST** Batch cooked, cooled, then reheated, which raises the resistant starch.

CAUTION Rinse well and cook in plenty of water, then drain. That lowers the naturally occurring arsenic.

56 Millet CORTISOL INSULIN

WHY A gluten free grain high in magnesium, the mineral your vessel walls need in order to relax rather than hold tension.

GOOD Cooked as a porridge. / **BETTER** As a pilaf with vegetables and herbs. / **BEST** Toasted dry in the pan first, then cooked, for a nutty flavour.

57 Teff INSULIN CORTISOL

WHY A tiny ancient Ethiopian grain, unusually rich in iron, magnesium and resistant starch for its size.

GOOD Cooked like oatmeal. / **BETTER** As the base of a bowl or as pancakes. / **BEST** Rotated with quinoa so you get a wider spread of minerals across the week.

58 Buckwheat NITRIC OXIDE INSULIN

WHY Not wheat at all, and not related to it. It carries rutin, a flavonoid studied for its support of the small blood vessels.

GOOD As a porridge. / **BETTER** Soba style noodles, checking the label says one hundred percent buckwheat. / **BEST** Toasted groats sprinkled over a salad for crunch.

59 Sprouted Whole Grain Bread INSULIN

WHY Sprouting the grain before milling makes it easier to digest and softens the blood sugar hit compared with white bread.

GOOD One slice toasted with avocado. / **BETTER** An open sandwich piled high with greens. / **BEST** Read the ingredients. The first word should be "sprouted", not "enriched".

CAUTION Bread is one of the largest hidden sodium sources in an ordinary week. Compare labels and pick the lowest one your shop carries.

60 **Air Popped Popcorn** INSULIN

WHY A whole grain that behaves like a snack. It replaces the chip habit, and the chip bag is where a lot of the day's sodium quietly hides.

GOOD Air popped and plain. / **BETTER** Sprinkled with nutritional yeast. / **BEST** With smoked paprika and garlic powder instead of salt.

CAUTION Microwave bags are a different food entirely. Buy plain kernels.

Nuts, Seeds and Good Fats

ITEMS 61 TO 72 · MAGNESIUM, AND THE FAT THAT HORMONES ARE BUILT FROM

This is the magnesium section, and magnesium is the mineral the muscle in your vessel walls needs in order to let go. It is also where the fat comes from, and your body cannot build a single hormone without fat. One rule governs the whole section: **buy them raw or dry roasted and unsalted.** The salted version hands straight back the very thing you came here for.

61 Chia Seeds INSULIN

WHY They swell into a gel in liquid, and that gel physically slows how quickly a meal turns into blood sugar.

GOOD Sprinkled on oats. / **BETTER** Chia pudding made overnight with plant milk. / **BEST** A tablespoon soaked, twice a day.

CAUTION Always soak them or eat them with plenty of liquid. Dry chia can swell in the throat.

62 Hemp Seeds CORTISOL

WHY A complete plant protein carrying magnesium and plant omega 3, with a mild flavour that disappears into anything.

GOOD Sprinkled over a salad. / **BETTER** Three tablespoons a day across meals. / **BEST** Blended with water into a two minute hemp milk.

63 Pumpkin Seeds CORTISOL ALDOSTERONE

WHY One of the richest food sources of magnesium there is, plus zinc, which the body uses in building hormones.

GOOD Scattered on a salad. / **BETTER** A small handful daily. / **BEST** Blended into a green pesto with cilantro and lime.

CAUTION Raw or dry roasted only. Never the salted kind.

64 Sunflower Seeds THYROID

WHY Vitamin E and selenium, and selenium is a mineral your thyroid gland simply cannot work without.

GOOD Sprinkled on oats. / **BETTER** In a trail mix with dried apricots. / **BEST** Sunflower seed butter on toast instead of a sugary spread.

CAUTION Store in the fridge. The oils turn rancid quickly at room temperature.

65 Sesame Seeds and Tahini ALDOSTERONE CORTISOL

WHY Calcium, magnesium and lignans, the same family of plant compounds as flaxseed, studied for their gentle role in hormone balance. Black sesame carries the most.

GOOD Sprinkled over a stir fry. / **BETTER** Tahini whisked with lemon and water into a dressing. / **BEST** Blended into hummus and sauces in place of creamy dairy dressings.

66 Walnuts NITRIC OXIDE CORTISOL

WHY The nut highest in plant omega 3, studied more than most for its support of the vessel lining.

GOOD A small handful. / **BETTER** Chopped over a salad. / **BEST** Blended into a dressing for creaminess without dairy.

CAUTION Food amounts are fine on a blood thinner. High dose concentrated omega 3 capsules are a different matter and need your prescriber's approval.

67 Almonds CORTISOL

WHY Magnesium, vitamin E and fat that slows the whole meal down behind it.

GOOD A handful as a snack. / **BETTER** Almond butter on apple slices. / **BEST** Soaked overnight, which makes them easier to digest.

CAUTION Unsalted only.

68 Pistachios ALDOSTERONE

WHY High potassium, fibre and plant protein, and the shells slow your hand down so you eat a sensible amount without trying.

GOOD A small handful, in the shell. / **BETTER** Chopped over a grain dish. / **BEST** Blended into a cream for desserts.

CAUTION Almost always sold salted. Look for unsalted, or rinse and dry them.

69 Brazil Nuts **THYROID**

WHY The single richest food source of selenium, which the thyroid uses to convert its hormone into the active form.

GOOD One nut a day. / **BETTER** Two, chopped into a trail mix. / **BEST** Stop at two. This is the one food on the list where more is genuinely not better.

CAUTION Selenium is easy to overdo. One or two nuts a day is plenty. A handful, daily, is too much.

70 Cashews **CORTISOL**

WHY Magnesium, and a creamy texture that lets you replace dairy in sauces without anybody at the table noticing.

GOOD A small handful. / **BETTER** Soaked and blended into a cream. / **BEST** As a cashew and lemon dressing poured over greens.

CAUTION Unsalted.

71 Extra Virgin Olive Oil **NITRIC OXIDE**

WHY Polyphenols and monounsaturated fat, the fat most consistently studied alongside heart health.

GOOD Drizzled over a salad. / **BETTER** A light saute rather than a hard fry. / **BEST** Used cold, where the polyphenols survive intact.

CAUTION Buy it in a dark bottle and keep it out of the light. Light spoils the very compounds you paid for.

72 Olives **CORTISOL**

WHY Healthy fat and polyphenols in a salty tasting food that genuinely satisfies the craving salt usually answers.

GOOD Four or five as a snack. / **BETTER** Chopped into a salad instead of adding salt to it. / **BEST** Rinsed, then blended into a tapenade with herbs and lemon.

CAUTION Olives are cured in salt. Treat them as the salt for that meal rather than as an extra on top of it.

Kitchen Herbs and Spices

ITEMS 73 TO 84 · HOW YOU STOP MISSING THE SALT

This section does two jobs at once. Every one of these carries something the body can use, and every one of them makes low salt food taste like real food rather than like a punishment. That second job is the one that decides whether you are still doing this in six months. Nothing here is at medicinal strength. These are seasonings, and you can start using all twelve tonight.

73 Turmeric CORTISOL

WHY Curcumin, studied for calming the low grade inflammation that stiffens blood vessels quietly over years.

GOOD Sprinkled over roasted vegetables. / **BETTER** Stirred into soups, stews and curries. / **BEST** A golden drink of turmeric, cinnamon and warm plant milk, with black pepper and a little fat, which is how the body actually absorbs it.

CAUTION Cooking amounts are fine. Concentrated capsules have a mild blood thinning effect and need your prescriber's approval if you take a blood thinner.

74 Ginger NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Warming, settles the stomach, and traditionally used to support circulation to the hands and feet.

GOOD Sliced into hot water as an infusion. / **BETTER** Grated into a stir fry. / **BEST** Fresh ginger blended into a morning smoothie. Freeze the root and grate it straight from frozen.

CAUTION Mild blood thinning effect. Keep to cooking amounts on warfarin, clopidogrel, apixaban, rivaroxaban or daily aspirin.

75 Cinnamon, Ceylon INSULIN

WHY Studied for its support of steadier blood sugar, and it makes food taste sweet without a grain of sugar in it.

GOOD On oats. / **BETTER** In smoothies and baking. / **BEST** Ceylon rather than cassia for daily use.

CAUTION Cassia cinnamon, the cheap supermarket kind, contains coumarin, which is hard on the liver in large daily amounts. Ceylon is the safer everyday choice.

76 Black Pepper INSULIN

WHY It multiplies how much curcumin you absorb from turmeric, and it seasons a plate where salt used to sit.

GOOD Ground over everything. / **BETTER** Paired with turmeric in the same dish, every time. / **BEST** Ground fresh from a mill. Pre ground pepper loses its punch within weeks.

77 Cayenne and Chilli NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Capsaicin, studied for its support of blood flow. Heat also makes low salt food taste like something, which is half the battle.

GOOD A pinch stirred into soup. / **BETTER** Fresh chilli in a stir fry. / **BEST** A chilli and garlic oil kept by the stove to finish plates instead of salt.

CAUTION Mild blood thinning effect at high supplement doses. Cooking amounts are fine.

78 Parsley ALDOSTERONE

WHY A gentle natural diuretic carrying potassium and vitamin K, and one of the few herbs you can eat by the handful.

GOOD Chopped over anything. / **BETTER** A whole bunch blended into tabbouleh. / **BEST** In a green sauce with lemon, garlic and olive oil, spooned over beans.

CAUTION High in vitamin K. On warfarin, keep the amount steady rather than eating it in bursts.

79 Cilantro CORTISOL

WHY Bright fresh flavour that replaces salt outright, and traditionally used to support the body's own clearing pathways.

GOOD Scattered over soups and beans. / **BETTER** Blended into a fresh salsa. / **BEST** As a pesto with pumpkin seeds, lime and olive oil.

80 Basil CORTISOL

WHY Aromatic anti inflammatory compounds, and it makes a tomato dish taste finished without reaching for the shaker.

GOOD Torn over a plate at the end. / **BETTER** Blended into a pesto with walnuts. / **BEST** Added right at the end of cooking. Heat destroys the aroma you paid for.

81 Oregano CORTISOL

WHY One of the highest antioxidant herbs by weight, and a traditional natural antimicrobial.

GOOD Dried, over roasted vegetables. / **BETTER** Fresh, torn into salads. / **BEST** Steeped as a simple infusion when you feel something coming on.

82 Rosemary NITRIC OXIDE

WHY Traditionally used to support circulation and alertness. The aroma alone lifts a room, which is not nothing on a hard day.

GOOD On roasted potatoes and squash. / **BETTER** Infused into olive oil. / **BEST** A sprig steeped in hot water in the afternoon, instead of a stimulant drink.

CAUTION In concentrated medicinal amounts rosemary can interact with blood thinners. Cooking and infusion amounts are fine.

83 Thyme CORTISOL

WHY Traditionally used for the chest and the airways, and it seasons beans and root vegetables beautifully.

GOOD Into soups and stews. / **BETTER** Steeped as an infusion with lemon. / **BEST** Cooked slowly with root vegetables and white beans.

84 Mint CORTISOL

WHY Cooling, settles the stomach, and it turns plain water into something you will actually finish, which is half of the water pillar solved.

GOOD A few leaves in your water bottle. / **BETTER** Steeped as an after dinner infusion. / **BEST** Chopped fresh into salads and fruit.

CAUTION If you get reflux, peppermint can loosen the valve at the top of the stomach and make it worse. Spearmint is gentler.

Caffeine Free Drinks and Infusions

ITEMS 85 TO 91 · EVERY SINGLE ONE, CAFFEINE FREE ON PURPOSE

There is no coffee, no black tea, no green tea and no matcha anywhere in this guide, and that is a deliberate decision, not an oversight. Stimulants trigger an adrenaline release, lift heart rate and tighten vessels, which pours fuel on a cortisol corner that is usually already running hot. Everything below gives you the ritual of a hot cup without the push. Hibiscus, the strongest of them all, is item 7.

85 Water **ALDOSTERONE**

WHY When you run dry, the body clings to sodium harder and tightens things that do not need to be tight. Water is the cheapest item in this entire guide and the one most people skip.

GOOD A tall glass on waking. / **BETTER** A bottle with you all day, refilled three times. / **BEST** Pale yellow urine as your daily check.

CAUTION If you have heart failure or kidney disease and have been given a fluid limit, follow the limit your prescriber gave you, not this page.

86 Rooibos **CORTISOL**

WHY A naturally caffeine free red bush infusion carrying antioxidants, and it drinks like a proper cup of tea when you are missing one.

GOOD One cup in the evening. / **BETTER** Two a day, replacing a caffeinated drink. / **BEST** With cinnamon and a splash of oat milk, as the afternoon ritual.

87 Chamomile **CORTISOL**

WHY A calming evening infusion. Better sleep is one of the most direct routes there is to bringing an overworked cortisol rhythm back into line.

GOOD One cup before bed. / **BETTER** Every night at the same time, so it becomes a signal your body recognises. / **BEST** Steeped covered for ten minutes, which keeps the volatile oils in the cup.

CAUTION Chamomile is in the ragweed family. Skip it if that is one of your allergies.

88 Roasted Chicory Root **INSULIN**

WHY It brews dark and bitter with no caffeine at all, and it carries inulin, a fibre that feeds the good bacteria in the gut.

GOOD One cup in the morning as a swap. / **BETTER** With cinnamon and plant milk. / **BEST** As a full replacement for the morning stimulant habit.

CAUTION The inulin can cause wind and bloating at first. Start with a small cup and build up.

89 Lemon Water **NITRIC OXIDE**

WHY Vitamin C, and it makes plain water pleasant enough that you actually drink the amount you meant to.

GOOD Warm with a squeeze, first thing. / **BETTER** With ginger slices added. / **BEST** A jug infused overnight with lemon, cucumber and mint, kept in the fridge door.

CAUTION Acid is hard on tooth enamel. Use a straw, or rinse your mouth with plain water afterwards.

90 Coconut Water **ALDOSTERONE**

WHY Naturally high in potassium, and it replaces what you lose through sweat on a hot day or after a long walk.

GOOD A small glass, chilled. / **BETTER** Blended into a smoothie. / **BEST** Unsweetened only. Read the label, many brands add sugar.

CAUTION This is concentrated potassium in liquid form. On an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or spironolactone, or with kidney disease, ask your prescriber before making it a daily habit.

91 Unsweetened Plant Milks **INSULIN**

WHY Almond, oat and soy milks carry fortified calcium and vitamin D with none of the animal fat, and soy milk brings useful plant protein as well.

GOOD On cereal. / **BETTER** In smoothies and overnight oats. / **BEST** Unsweetened and fortified, or made at home to avoid the additives entirely.

CAUTION Sweetened versions can carry a surprising amount of sugar. The word you are looking for on the carton is "unsweetened".

Ferments, Sea Vegetables and Flavour Builders

ITEMS 92 TO 96 · SMALL AMOUNTS, REAL EFFECT

A healthy gut is part of how the body clears used hormones instead of recycling them, and ferments are the cheapest way to feed it. Sea vegetables are here for a different reason entirely: iodine, for the thyroid. Read every caution in this section carefully. These are the items where a small amount helps and a large amount does not.

92 Sauerkraut **INSULIN**

WHY Live cultures for the gut, and a healthy gut is part of how used hormones leave the body rather than circulating around again.

GOOD One tablespoon a day. / **BETTER** On top of a grain bowl. / **BEST** Raw and unpasteurised, from the chilled section. Shelf stable jars have no live cultures left.

CAUTION It is fermented in salt. One tablespoon, not a bowl, and count it as the salt for that meal. Never heat it, heat kills the cultures.

93 Miso **INSULIN**

WHY A fermented soy paste with live cultures and a deep savoury flavour that satisfies the exact craving salt usually answers.

GOOD Whisked into a dressing. / **BETTER** Stirred, never boiled, into a warm broth with seaweed and tofu. / **BEST** As a glaze on roasted vegetables and mushrooms.

CAUTION Miso is salty. Use it as the salt in a dish, never alongside it. Half a teaspoon is a serving if you are watching sodium closely.

94 Nutritional Yeast **CORTISOL**

WHY Usually fortified with B12, the one vitamin a plant based plate genuinely needs help with, plus B vitamins the adrenal glands run on. It tastes rich and savoury with no dairy anywhere near it.

GOOD Shaken over popcorn. / **BETTER** Blended into sauces for depth. / **BEST** A daily sprinkle over bowls and pasta, choosing a fortified brand.

95 Sea Vegetables: Nori, Dulse and Kelp **THYROID**

WHY The most reliable plant source of iodine, and the thyroid cannot make its hormone without iodine. Thyroid hormone moves blood pressure in both directions, so this is a corner worth getting right.

GOOD A nori sheet as a snack. / **BETTER** Dulse flakes shaken over avocado toast instead of salt. / **BEST** Small amounts several times a week, never large amounts daily.

CAUTION Read this one twice. Iodine is potent, and kelp in particular can be extremely concentrated. Too much iodine disturbs the thyroid just as surely as too little does. If you have a thyroid condition or take thyroid medication, ask your prescriber first. Kelp is also salty.

96 Apple Cider Vinegar **INSULIN**

WHY Taken with a meal, vinegar is studied for blunting the blood sugar rise from that meal, which means a smaller insulin response behind it.

GOOD In a salad dressing. / **BETTER** A teaspoon in a large glass of water before a starchy meal. / **BEST** Raw, with the cloudy sediment still in the bottle.

CAUTION Always dilute it. Undiluted vinegar damages tooth enamel and can irritate the throat. If you take insulin or a diabetes medication, tell your prescriber, because it can add to their blood sugar effect.

Herbs to Ask About First

ITEMS 97 TO 101 · NOT SEASONINGS, AND NOT OPTIONAL READING

These five are different from everything else in this guide. They are herbs used at strength, they can genuinely move your physiology, and every one of them can add to a medication you may already be taking. They are here because people ask about them constantly and deserve a straight answer, not because you need them. Nothing here is dangerous in the way people fear herbs are dangerous. The risk is not poison. The risk is **addition**, and low blood pressure lands people in the emergency department too. Take this page to your prescriber before you start any of them.

97 Hawthorn NITRIC OXIDE

WHY The traditional Western heart herb, used for centuries for circulation and for the strength of the heartbeat. The most asked about herb on this entire list.

HOW IT IS USED As a leaf and flower infusion, or as a standardised extract, usually daily, and always alongside a prescriber who knows you are taking it.

CAUTION This is the important one. Hawthorn can add to the effect of blood pressure medication and take your pressure lower than anyone planned. It also interacts with digoxin. **Do not start hawthorn on your own if you take a blood pressure medication or digoxin. Ask your prescriber first, every time.**

98 Olive Leaf NITRIC OXIDE

WHY The leaf of the same tree that gives you the oil, carrying oleuropein, studied for its support of relaxed vessels.

HOW IT IS USED As an infusion or a standardised extract, usually once daily.

CAUTION Because it works in the same direction as your medication, it can add to it. Ask your prescriber before starting, and check your readings more often for the first two weeks.

99 Celery Seed ALDOSTERONE

WHY A concentrated form of the compounds found in the celery stalk, traditionally used to support fluid balance.

HOW IT IS USED As a seed extract, or the whole seeds ground into cooking, which is the gentler way in.

CAUTION It has a mild diuretic effect, so it can stack with a prescription water pill and it can affect lithium levels. Not in pregnancy. Ask before you start.

100 Dandelion Leaf ALDOSTERONE

WHY A traditional gentle diuretic, and unusually for a diuretic, the leaf carries potassium rather than stripping it out.

HOW IT IS USED As a leaf infusion, or the young leaves eaten in a spring salad, which is the gentlest form of all.

CAUTION Two reasons to ask first. It can add to a prescription water pill, and because it carries potassium it can add to an ACE inhibitor, an ARB or spironolactone.

101 Nettle Leaf ALDOSTERONE

WHY A mineral rich traditional tonic, mildly diuretic, drunk for generations as a spring tea. A gentle place to finish a list of one hundred and one.

HOW IT IS USED As a leaf infusion, steeped ten minutes, once daily for a few weeks at a time rather than forever.

CAUTION It can add to a prescription water pill, and it is high in vitamin K, which matters a great deal on warfarin. Ask before you make it a daily habit.

Your first ten days.

One new item a day. Not ten today. One. Keep every one you add, so by day ten you are running all ten at once and none of them felt like effort.

Day	Add this	How, in one line
One	Spinach	Two handfuls wilted into whatever you were already cooking for dinner.
Two	Water	A tall glass on waking, before anything else touches your mouth.
Three	Rolled oats	Half a cup dry, cooked in water, with cinnamon. Breakfast is now handled.
Four	Ground flaxseed	One tablespoon on the oats you started yesterday.
Five	Black beans	Rinse the can. Half a cup into anything savoury.
Six	Garlic	Crush two cloves, let them sit ten minutes, then cook them.
Seven	The walk	Ten minutes after your biggest meal. Not a workout. A walk.
Eight	Beets	Half a cup of cooked or jarred beets. Pink urine tomorrow is normal.
Nine	Hibiscus	One cup, steeped strong. Check the blend has no licorice in it.
Ten	Morning light	Five to fifteen minutes outside within an hour of waking.

WHAT TO DO ON DAY ELEVEN

Nothing new. Run the same ten for another fortnight until they stop being decisions and start being habits. Then open the list again and pick three more. **Slow is the whole strategy.** People who add ten things in one week are the same people who have added nothing by the following month.

WHILE YOU DO THIS

Write your reading and the date, once a day, in the same notebook. Ten days of numbers is the single most useful thing you can put in front of your prescriber. **And do not change any medication. That decision belongs to them, always.**

The pantry reset, and how to read a label in ten seconds.

Most of the sodium in a normal week is not in the shaker. It is already in the packet before you get home. This page is how you find it.

Clear

The sneaky sugars first: sweetened cereal, granola bars, fruit juice, soda. Then the refined oils, then the white carbohydrates, the bread, crackers and pastries that turn into blood sugar almost as fast as sugar does.

Swap

Instead of	Reach for
White bread	Sprouted whole grain bread, lowest sodium brand on the shelf
Chips and crisps	Air popped popcorn, or roasted chickpeas
Soda and juice	Sparkling water with lemon, or cooled hibiscus
Sweetened cereal	Overnight oats with berries and ground flaxseed
The salt shaker	Garlic powder, onion powder, smoked paprika, lemon zest, black pepper
Salted nuts	The same nut, raw or dry roasted, unsalted
Jarred pasta sauce	Tinned tomatoes cooked down with onion, garlic and basil
Coffee or black tea	Roasted chicory, rooibos, or hibiscus. Every one caffeine free

Stock

Use the 101 list as your shopping list. Beans, lentils, oats, brown rice, quinoa, nuts, seeds, dried fruit, tinned tomatoes, frozen vegetables and frozen berries. Frozen is not second best. It is picked ripe and it does not rot in your fridge while you feel guilty about it.

Reading a label in ten seconds

Three numbers. Sodium, sugar, fibre. In that order, for this audience.

- **Sodium.** Anything at or over 500mg per serving is a lot for one item. Check the serving size before you feel relieved, because it is often half of what you would actually eat.
- **Sugar.** More than 6g per serving is worth a second look. Watch for the words ending in "ose", and for syrups, concentrates and anything called "natural cane".
- **Fibre.** Under 2g means the grain has been stripped. That is the fastest way to spot a food that will spike your sugar and pull insulin up behind it.
- **Then the ingredients.** If oil is in the first three, or there are more than five or six things you do not recognise, put it back.

ONE HABIT WORTH MORE THAN THE REST OF THIS PAGE

Compare two brands of the same thing, once a week. Bread, tinned tomatoes, plant milk, soup. The gap between the best and worst brand of the same product is usually enormous, and it costs you nothing but ten seconds in the aisle.

Two plate rules, and nine meals under ten minutes.

Plate rule one. Eat heaviest in the morning.

Most people run the day backwards. Light breakfast, huge dinner, then they wonder why they are exhausted at three, craving sugar at four and wide awake at midnight. Your body handles carbohydrate better earlier in the day, and the evening is for repair rather than heavy digestion. Front load it. Heaviest at breakfast, steady at lunch, lightest at night.

Plate rule two. More green than any other colour.

Not a rule about calories. A rule about the ratio your kidney is reading. If green is the largest thing on the plate, the potassium takes care of itself.

Meal	Basic	Functional	Optimal
Breakfast heaviest	Whole grain toast with nut butter	Overnight oats with chia, berries and flaxseed	Quinoa, kale and black bean bowl with avocado
Lunch steady	Vegetable sandwich on sprouted bread	Big salad with beans and quinoa	Rainbow bowl: two cups greens, beans, roast vegetables, tahini
Dinner lightest	Light vegetable soup	Stir fry with tofu, broccoli and cauliflower rice	Steamed greens, a warm miso broth and tempeh

Nine meals you can make in under ten minutes

Base	Add	Flavour	Result
Tinned black beans, rinsed	Chopped spinach	Salsa	Black bean wrap
Frozen broccoli	Lentils	Tahini and lemon	Green bowl
Oats	Chia and flaxseed	Banana and cinnamon	Overnight oats
Chickpeas	Cucumber and tomato	Olive oil and lemon	Chickpea salad
Precooked brown rice	Edamame and kale	A teaspoon of tamari	Quick stir fry
Hummus	Carrot and celery sticks	Smoked paprika	Snack box
Whole grain wrap	Beans and greens	Salsa and lime	Wrap to go
Quinoa	Roasted frozen vegetables	Cashew cream	Power bowl
Frozen mango	Two cups spinach	Coconut water	Emergency smoothie

BATCH ONCE, EAT ALL WEEK

One pot of grain. Two pots of beans. Two leafy greens washed and chopped. One sheet pan of roast vegetables. Snacks portioned into small containers. That is about ninety minutes on a Sunday and it removes every single excuse from the following six days.

Your daily BALANCED tracker.

Health shifts when small wins stack up. Print this page, or copy the eight lines into a notebook. Tick what you did, spot your own patterns, and give yourself credit for the week you actually had.

BALANCED	Today's action	M	T	W	T	F	S
B Breathe & Belief	Three to five minutes of slow nasal breathing, plus prayer or gratitude						
A Activity	Twenty to thirty minute walk, or strength twice this week						
L Light	Five to fifteen minutes of morning sunlight						
A Abundant Plants	Two vegetables and one fruit per meal, green the largest						
N Nourish Water	Tall glass on waking, bottle refilled three times						
C Calm Moderation	Limit added sugar, no stimulants, screens down early						
E Early Rest	Seven or more hours, same bedtime						
D Devotion & Depth	Prayer, scripture, or a real conversation with someone						
Reading	Today's number, written down with the date						

Weekly reflection

- ☐ **Wins.**
Three things that went right this week. Write them before you write anything else.
- ☐ **Snags.**
One or two things that tripped you up, and what was actually going on that day.
- ☐ **Adjustment.**
Circle one BALANCED letter to focus on next week. One. Not four.
- ☐ **Scripture for the week.**
One verse to sit with.
- ☐ **Commitment.**
"This week I will _____."

MEASURE BACKWARDS, NOT FORWARDS

Do not measure this week against the perfect version of yourself. Measure it against where you were before you opened this guide. That is the only comparison that has ever kept anybody going.

If you want more, here is the whole path.

Nothing on this page is required. The guide in your hands is complete on its own and it cost you nothing. But people ask what comes next, so here it is, in order, with real prices and no games.

Free Beyond the Cuff, live every Monday

The masterclass on page two. Live at 7:00pm Central, questions answered out loud, nothing to buy on the call. A replay is not guaranteed, so come live if you can.

bpquiz.com/masterclass

\$17 The 10-Day BP Reset Kit

This guide tells you what to eat. The Kit tells you **what to do, in what order, for ten days**, built around whichever of the three pressures is loudest in your life. Eleven documents, delivered by email straight away.

What is inside	Value
Your 10-Day Reset Plan, built for your trigger	\$47
Your Herb Guide for that trigger	\$19
Your Bring To Your Doctor Sheet	\$9
The Master Blood Pressure Document	\$29
Top 10 Herbs Deep Dive	\$17
Cook For Life Cookbook	\$27
White Coat Syndrome Guide	\$9
BP FAQ	\$7
Overmedicated Boomers, the book	\$17
Your BP Tracker	\$9
The Triangle Meal Plan	\$19
Real value of the eleven documents	\$209
Your price	\$17

Feel-It-or-Free, 30 days. Run the full 10-day plan. If you do not feel a difference, reply with the word REFUND and your money comes back. Keep the books either way. No hoops, no fine print.

bpquiz.com/pay?tier=corner&corner=stress

\$27/month The Weekly Reset

Joel's community, with a live group call every Wednesday at 7:00pm Eastern. This is the one for people who do fine for three weeks and then drift. Cancel any time.

skool.com/braveworksrn/about

\$297 Your own 30-day protocol

Joel builds you a personalised, day by day, thirty day protocol from your own situation, your own readings and your own medication list. **This is a document, not a series of coaching calls.** You get a plan with your name on it.

bpquiz.com/coaching

\$1,997 The 90-Day programme

Ninety days, in a group, with Joel. For people who want the whole thing built and held in place rather than assembled from PDFs. Details and the current intake on the page.

bpquiz.com/allin

Every price on this page is the real price. There are no crossed out numbers that never existed, no countdown pretending a door is closing, and no seat counts we made up. If we ever tell you something is limited, it will be because it genuinely is.

You are not a patient here. You are the one in charge.

You were probably handed a prescription and a sentence that sounded like "let us watch it and see." Nobody sat you down and explained that the reading on that cuff is the end of a story, not the beginning of one, and that the story is written by three hormones with very ordinary names.

Now you know. Cortisol. Insulin. Aldosterone. And after fifty, the quieter shifts underneath them, oestrogen falling away from the vessel wall, testosterone drifting down, a thyroid nobody has checked in a decade. None of that is a character flaw and none of it is your fault. It is a mechanism. Mechanisms can be worked with.

Do not try to do all one hundred and one. Do ten. Do them for a fortnight. Write your numbers down. Then take this guide to your next appointment and have a better conversation than the last one, because you will be walking in with information instead of just hope.

Genetics writes the recipe. Lifestyle bakes the cake.

FROM BOTH OF US

Thank you for trusting two nurses with an hour of your attention.

Annie works with women through the hormone years. Joel spent twenty years in ICU and emergency rooms watching blood pressure readings and then went looking for what was pushing them. We wrote one guide because it turned out to be one subject.

Take care of the body you were given. It is the only one you get, and it is a great deal more willing to come back than anyone told you.

Annie & Joel

THE LINE THAT MATTERS MOST IN THIS WHOLE GUIDE

Do not stop, skip, or change the dose of any medication because of anything you have read here.

Talk to your prescriber. Bring your written readings. Ask for a potassium level if you are adding potassium rich foods. Your prescriber makes the medication decisions, always, and everything in this guide is designed to work alongside them, never instead of them.

Medical disclaimer. This guide is education and lifestyle support. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment, and it does not create a nurse and patient relationship. It is general information and it cannot account for your medical history, your medications, or your test results. Nothing in these pages is a promise about your blood pressure or any other number.

Always talk to your physician, nurse practitioner, physician assistant or pharmacist before changing what you eat, before starting any herb or supplement, and before changing anything about your medication. This is especially important if you are pregnant or nursing, if you have kidney disease, liver disease or heart failure, or if you take blood pressure medication, a blood thinner, a diuretic, thyroid medication, digoxin, lithium, or medication for diabetes. Herb and drug interactions listed in this guide are the common, well documented ones, and no list can be complete for every person. Your pharmacist has your full medication list in front of them and will check any of this for free.

If you have chest pain, trouble breathing, weakness on one side of the body, or a sudden severe headache, call 911.

Annie Chitate, RN and Joel Polley, RN · BraveWorks RN · BPQuiz.com · This is education and lifestyle support, not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.